The Israeli attack on Gaza, February 1955

Key question
Why did the Israelis attack Gaza?

However, Nasser wanted Egypt to be neutral and was not willing to join an anti-Soviet alliance. This worried the West. The Israelis were also worried, but for different reasons. They wanted to hit back at Egypt for encouraging Palestinian raids into Israel: they wanted to teach Nasser a lesson and, perhaps, remove him from power. The Israeli leader, Ben-Gurion, said to his cabinet:

> It is definitely possible to topple him and it is even a *mitzvah* [sacred obligation] to do so. Who is he anyway, this Nasser-Shmasser?

Key dates
Israeli attack on Gaza: February 1955
Egypt announced Czech arms deal: September 1955

One way to undermine him was to show him up as militarily weak. This way he would be cut down to size, to a mere 'Nasser-Shmasser'. In February 1955, Israeli troops attacked and destroyed the Egyptian army headquarters in Gaza and killed 35 Egyptian soldiers. For the next three days Palestinian refugees in Gaza ran riot and demanded: 'Arms, give us arms, we shall defend ourselves!' In Cairo, the Egyptian capital, the crowds wanted revenge too.

The Israeli attack on Gaza was, as intended, humiliating for Nasser. He knew that it could have a very damaging effect on his leadership of Egypt and his image in the wider Arab world. He urgently needed arms to strengthen Egypt's army and deter any further Israeli attacks. His forces now began to arm and train *fedayeen* **guerrillas** to carry out attacks in Israel. What was most crucial, however, was that he secured Soviet arms. This he did through Soviet Russia's communist ally, Czechoslovakia. The Czech arms deal was announced in September 1955.

Key term
Guerrillas
Soldiers who avoid fighting in open battle when possible; they prefer to use tactics like ambushes and hit-and-run raids.

The importance of the Aswan Dam

This was a shock to the West, as well as to Israel. However, Britain and the USA thought they could still control Nasser because he depended on them for money to build the Aswan High Dam. This was a huge project on the River Nile which would create hydroelectric power for Egyptian industry and allow vast areas of agricultural land to be irrigated. It was proclaimed as a symbol of the new, dynamic Egypt which would allow the country to catch up with the West.

Meanwhile Nasser continued to show that he would not be pushed around and that Egypt was determined to be neutral. In May 1956, he recognised communist China. At this time, Western countries did not allow China to take its place at the UN and claimed that Taiwan, which was non-communist, represented China. In July 1956, the USA and Britain decided to cancel their loans to Egypt for the building of the Aswan Dam. Perhaps they hoped to persuade Nasser to be more co-operative. Maybe they thought they could force the Egyptians to replace him.